SINCE AI HACKATHON 2026 · FONECTA CHALLENGE

Connect Suggests – Customer Approves

No customer walks to a closed door. And no owner has to log in to stop it.

Flovr · Alex, Vova and Zahar (Flovr's AI agent) · synthetic Fonecta dataset only

THE PROBLEM

Owners don't log in. So the hours go wrong exactly when it matters.

53%

of the 2025 pilot suggestions got **no reply at all** (1,610 of 3,031).

65% / 40%

reply rate on WhatsApp vs email in the same pilot. The channel matters as much as the suggestion.

~40%

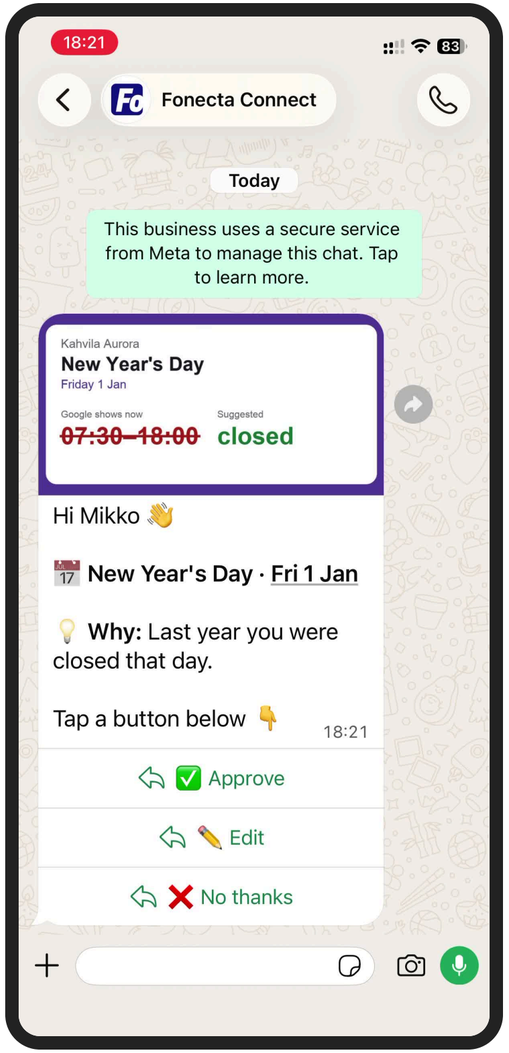
of needed changes have **no usable history** to copy (Fonecta's own note). That's where it gets hard.

Source: pilot_decision_log_2025.csv and the starter kit README, in the challenge dataset.

THE SOLUTION

The whole chain, working

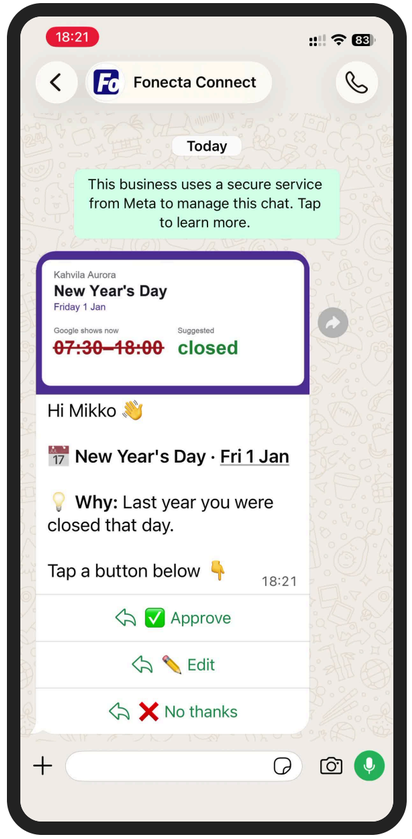
1. **Detect:** a model over every business × special day: own history, shopping centre, peers, last year's activity, closed-door reviews, Google user edits.
2. **Suggest:** the hours candidate with the best track record. Confident → suggest, unsure → ask, weak → stay quiet.
3. **Contact:** on WhatsApp, in the owner's language (fi/sv/nb/en). One message per date: what Google shows now, what we suggest, and why.
4. **Decide:** no login, no app. Approve / Edit / No thanks buttons. Edits are typed or spoken in the chat ("9 to 13").
5. **Apply:** written to Yext, then a confirmation of where it shows and how soon.



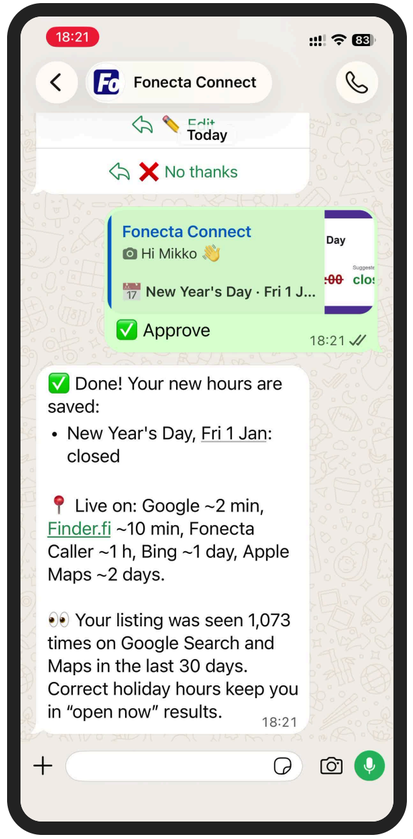
Real iPhone screen: our WhatsApp test number, synthetic business from the Fonecta dataset.

THE CUSTOMER EXPERIENCE

The owner never leaves WhatsApp



Ask: one date, the reason, three buttons



Confirm: live on Google in ~2 min, and their real search views



Urgent: a WhatsApp call when the date is close and nobody answered

Real iPhone screen recordings from the running app, 7 Nov. Free text uses Claude Haiku (Gemini fallback); voice notes are transcribed locally with Whisper.

RELIABILITY

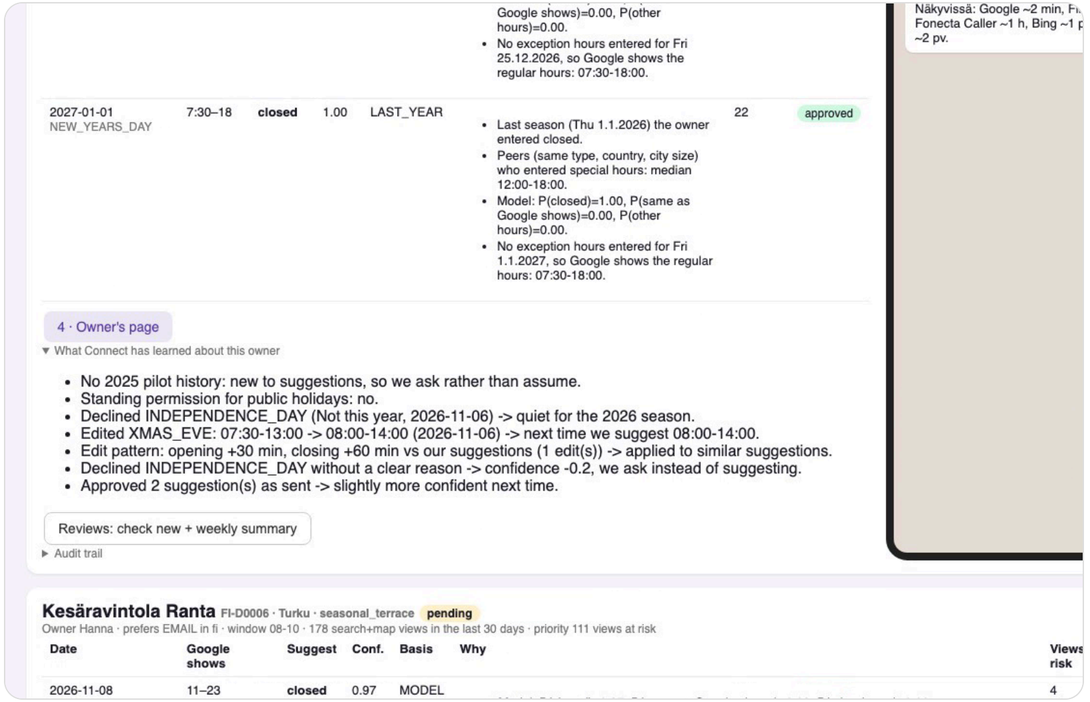
The customer always has the last word

- Nothing reaches Yext without an owner decision, a standing permission (public holidays, confident only, followed by an inform message with one-tap **Undo**) or an undo. That's enforced in code and unit-tested.
- Unsure → we **ask**, never assume (new customer with no history: questions, not guesses).
- Looks closed for good → **flagged to a human**, no message.
- Hours already right → **silence**.
- No answer → backup approver after 24 h → one **WhatsApp voice call** when it's 48 h away. The call never approves anything.
- Every suggestion keeps its reasons, the message and the answer: a full **audit trail**.

HOW IT LEARNS

Every answer makes the next suggestion better

- **Edit** → remembered for that day, and the pattern (e.g. +1 h) applies to similar days.
- **"Open as usual" / "Not this year"** → that day goes quiet.
- **No reason given** → lower confidence: next time we ask instead of suggest.
- **Standing permission** → applied, then the owner is informed.
- 2025 pilot decisions seed each owner's history from day one.



Screenshot: the live ops console after the demo owner edited Christmas Eve and declined Independence Day ("Not this year").

RESULTS · FONECTA'S SCORING SCRIPT

Better than the baseline, on businesses the model never saw

	Score	Exact precision	Recall	Search views protected	Harmful
Baseline (kit)	54.5	0.90	0.59	57%	224
Ours (5-fold by business)	**61.8**	0.84	**0.70**	**69%**	396

The honest part: we find far more of the wrong hours, at the cost of more wrong-state guesses. In the product, anything under 0.6 confidence becomes a **question** rather than a suggestion, and nothing is published without the owner.

Dev split 2026, out-of-fold. predictions_2026.csv (all target rows) is in the repo for the hidden test split.

EXTENSIBILITY + LIVE DATA

One loop, many jobs

- **Reviews:** a bad review gets a reply drafted in its language → owner posts / edits / skips → Yext Reviews API. Plus a weekly "what people praised" summary.
- **Live events** (bonus): Helsinki LinkedEvents, live. A concert 650 m away ends 20:15 → "Stay open till 21:15?". 5 of 106 Helsinki restaurants got one this weekend. No attendance data is the gap.
- **Channel-agnostic:** one decision engine, any channel. Live today: WhatsApp (buttons, chat edits, voice notes) and WhatsApp voice calls. Built and switched off: SMS (for owners without smartphones) and iMessage.
- **Decision log:** every suggestion, answer and change in one table, per business: who, what, when, which channel.
- **Staff shifts** (synthetic schedule) and **watched pages** ("watch this page for events near my café"): the same ask-then-apply loop.

PRIVACY, SECURITY AND AI

Responsible by default

- **Data:** only the synthetic Fonecta dataset and public Helsinki events. No real customer data.
- **Secrets:** Yext, WhatsApp and Gemini keys live in the keychain and env vars. None in the repo, its history, the video or this deck.
- **Control:** no write without the owner (enforced in code, unit-tested). No-login links are signed and expire.
- **Messaging:** WhatsApp only after the owner writes first or with an approved template; calls only with call permission; opt-outs respected.
- **AI in the product:** Claude Haiku reads free-text replies (Gemini fallback). Its output is validated, and it never decides. Whisper runs locally, so audio stays on our machine.
- **Suggestions** come from a classic model with reasons we can show, not a chatbot.
- **Built with AI:** Zahar (Flovr's agent, Claude Code) wrote most of the code; every result was checked by running it.
- **Pre-existing:** built on Fonecta's starter kit (MIT); everything else was built at the event. Zahar's own platform stays out of the repo.

NEXT STEPS

From demo to December

- Pilot with Connect customers before Christmas: WhatsApp-first, measure the reply rate against 2025's 47%.
- Get the WhatsApp utility template approved in fi/sv/nb/en.
- Voice and WhatsApp-first rollout: calls, voice notes and chat edits in fi/sv/nb/en.
- Add attendance data (ticketing / venues) to the event signal. Norway launch: MET + local calendars.

github.com/zahar-io/fonecta (public) · demo video: 2 min, real app